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LIVE INVESTMENT MEMO
ONE DEAL, IC-READY

PROBETRUTH Neurosymbolic deepfake detection for regulated sectors • Ann Arbor / UM-Flint

RECOMMEND:
PARTICIPATE

\$3M

ROUND BEING RAISED

\$1.5M

NON-DILUTIVE IN
PRE-ROUND

2025

U-M TECH TRANSFER
COHORT

1 of 31

U-M SPINOUTS THAT YEAR

50

HEADCOUNT TARGET,
YE26

THE THESIS

Why this company, why now, why a co-investor can win the allocation

01

Regulated buyers, not consumers

Courts, banks, and insurers must prove media provenance under evidentiary and KYC rules. That converts deepfake detection from a feature into a compliance line item with a budget owner.

02

Explainability is the moat

A neurosymbolic architecture pairs pattern recognition with logical reasoning, so it outputs a defensible rationale. A pure-CNN detector cannot survive cross-examination; this one is built to.

03

Founder pairing is the rare part

A repeat founder with a legal-tech exit alongside the U-M researcher who authored the patents. Domain depth plus a second-time operator is the combination that clears seed diligence.

THE LEAD INVESTOR THESIS

No lead is committed. We do not write until one is, and not just any one

WHO SHOULD LEAD

A **security or fraud-infrastructure seed specialist** with prior enterprise-compliance exits, not a generalist AI fund. The buyer is a risk officer, so the lead must have sold into that seat before and be able to open those doors.

WHY IT MATTERS

In a co-investment model the lead **is part of the asset**. At \$3M pre-Series A, the lead sets the price, the governance, and the next round's syndicate. A weak lead here caps the company at pilots and strands the follow-on.

WHAT I WANT TO SEE

Two prior seed leads that graduated to a priced A within 24 months; a partner who takes the board seat personally; and conviction expressed as ownership target, not as a small check spread across a large portfolio.

WHAT DISQUALIFIES

A first-time micro-fund, a party round with no clear price-setter, or a strategic taking outsized rights early. Any of the three and I recommend we pass and revisit at the A.

WHAT WOULD MAKE ME WRONG

Pre-registered, so the follow-on or write-off call is defensible later

Pilots never price

Non-dilutive funding and pilots prove interest, not willingness to pay. Regulated procurement cycles run long.

Kill signal. Fewer than three pilots converted to paid contracts by the round's close.

The adversary moves faster

Detection is an arms race against generation models improving monthly. Accuracy decays without continuous retraining.

Kill signal. Benchmark accuracy falling year over year on current-generation synthetic media.

Talent density in Flint

The plan targets 50 people by year end against a thin local senior AI market and coastal salary competition.

Kill signal. Senior research hires slipping two quarters or filled below the stated bar.

THE ASK. Approve a conditional allocation into the \$3M round, releasable only once a qualifying lead prices it on the criteria above. I would run reference calls with two pilot customers and one prior investor, and hold the check until paid-conversion evidence clears. **If no qualifying lead emerges, we pass and re-underwrite at the Series A.**